Getting started with Meteor

Meteor isn't just a simple JS framework, it's much more powerful and here's how you can get started with it.

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INTRODUCTION

Meteor is essentially a platform for building Full-Stack Node Applications. It's entirely open source, allows for seamless deployment onto any platform, provides a whole host of packages to assist in building real time applications and has ultra rapid prototyping capabilities and features. Developers are free to use any front end framework of their choice, and while Meteor, by default, provides extensive integration with MongoDB, any database with a node.js driver is supported. All this combined makes Meteor an excellent framework for both newcomers and professionals, it's easily manageable by both small and large teams, and is capable of building both hackathon worthy and large scalable apps.

SO WHY DOES IT EXIST?

Meteor was initially designed with the intention to assist with real-time features for the apps built with it. However, over time, it expanded its scope and today has the following key features:

- **Build entirely using Javascript for every platform:** There is no need to use other languages for your backend like Java or Python. The code base can be developed for Android, iOS and web browsers simultaneously all within Meteor and JS.
- **Data on the Wire:** The server will only send relevant data instead of entire HTML files, for the client to render. This ensures snappy, real-time updates with clean subscription systems to consistently monitor changes on the server side.
- **Large ecosystem of relevant packages:** Meteor bundles a curated list of packages from the general JS and Node JS communities which are extremely beneficial to the development of a wide variety of applications. As a developer, you spend less time package hunting and more time developing and fine tuning.
- **Meteor Cloud:** Meteor provides its own application hosting service as well, with free tiers for experimentation and small scale apps. There are paid tiers as well with decent price tags associated with it whether an organisation or individual wishes to upgrade the performance and capacity of their server. The integration with the development process is what sells Meteor Cloud, and makes the process of hosting it as smooth as possible.
- **Massive community support:** Meteor is not only used by prominent companies such as Qualcomm, Ikea and Honeywell, it is also supported by a developer team of nearly 650 developers and over 31,500+ commits since the initial launch of the project. There are several built-in quality of life features such as a LiveReload on changing the codebase.It also has community built packages which further ease development, such as the accounts-password package which streamlines account creation and authentication.

SO HOW DO WE GET STARTED?

Note: This tutorial will assume you have basic to intermediate familiarity with javascript and node development.

Let us first go through a quick checklist of pre-requisites before running that npm install command:

- If you are using a Mac with an M1 chip, you will need Rosetta 2 installed for Meteor to properly run MongoDB. Simply running the following command should do the trick: